

A Perspective on History

When did the study of ethics begin? Who were the great thinkers in the history of ethics? what contributions did they make?

This chapter is as much a beginning as a conclusion. It opens the way for you to deepen your understanding of the subject of ethics, to become acquainted with some of the great ethical thinkers and thoughts of the past, even as you continue to apply your evaluative skills to the ethical problems of today. You will probably appreciate its contents more now than you would have if you had read it at the outset, for now you have struggled with numerous ethical issues yourself, felt the pull of conflicting values, wrestled with moral dilemmas to which no answer seems completely satisfactory. Now, too, you know the value of careful analysis and a systematic approach. This will enable you to appreciate the ideas advanced by the various ethicists as they attempted to construct an ethical system. Even when you do not share their philosophic perspective, you will understand their efforts and share their enthusiasm for the task.

Historians usually divide the history of ethics in Western thought into three large periods: the classical, the medieval, and the modern. Any division, naturally, is arbitrary. There are no real breaks in time; the flow of moment to moment is constant. Nevertheless, the divisions are convenient. They help us to grasp major developments more fully and see shifting focuses and changing perspectives more sharply.

THE CLASSICAL PERIOD

The classical period of ethical thought extends from 500 B.C. to A.D. 500. At the beginning of this period a rapid change was taking place in Greek society. Once an agrarian monarchy, it was now becoming a commercial industrial democracy. New changes brought new challenges to old values and traditions. The ethics of the time reflected the central feature of the society, the city-state. Thus the moral focus was the duty of the individual as a citizen. Ethics was regarded as the spiritual counterpart of medicine, its function being to provide care of the soul as medicine provides care of the body. With values in flux, a number of moral views arose to clash with the to what extent morality was a matter of nature and to what extent a matter of custom or tradition. Their general view was that good and evil are matters of personal decision or social agreement. Some of the more liberal Sophists suggested that all morality was a matter of convenience only.

Socrates (469-399 B.C.) was the dominant figure of the classical period. Indeed, he is generally regarded as **the father of Western philosophy**. He left no writings, but many of his views were recorded in the writings of his pupil Plato. **Like the Sophists, Socrates rejected the idea that tradition justifies conduct. But unlike them, he believed that morality is more than a matter of personal choice or convenience.** It is possible, he believed, to develop a universal set of ethical principles to guide conduct, and the key to doing so is human reason, the careful examination of beliefs and actions and the logic that underlies them. **His focus was on self-knowledge. "The unexamined life," he taught, "is not worth living."**

Socrates is best known for his philosophical method. Rather than teach directly, he conversed with others, asking basic questions about important matters (for example, What is justice? What is virtue?) and then examining the answers people gave, exposing vagueness and inconsistency, clarifying problems, and pointing the way to further inquiry. He was also the first to probe the relationships between

facts and values an ethical issue that virtually all ethicists since his time have grappled with.

Plato (427-347 B.C.) built upon the teaching of Socrates. Plato's writings are in dialogue form, and Socrates is the main character in most of them. Plato's greatest work is *The Republic*. He shared Socrates' view that the life of reason is the happiest and best life. For both men sense perception and bodily pleasure were less desirable than intellectual pursuits, but the two men differed somewhat in their emphases. Socrates apparently believed in enjoying himself at all levels of experience in a balanced way. He believed that nothing should be done to excess, that moderation should be the rule in everything. Plato's view was more extreme. His denial of bodily pleasure and sense perception made him a model for later religious and idealistic ethicists.

Plato's central notion was that the real world is not the world that our senses perceive, but the world of ideas. The concrete reality that surrounds us, in Plato's view, is merely an imperfect reflection of the world of abstract ideas or "forms," which are timeless and unchanging. The most important reality in this world of ideas is the idea of the Good. Goodness for Plato was a central fact about the universe. Thus the main goal of his ethical system is to gain a vision of the Good.

Aristotle (384-322 B.C.) was a student of Plato and followed his and Socrates' philosophical tradition. Nevertheless, Aristotle's emphasis was quite different from Plato's. Aristotle authored as many as four hundred works on a variety of subjects from theoretical and practical science to politics, rhetoric, logic, and ethics. His *Nicomachean Ethics* is the first systematic treatment of ethics in Western civilization.

Aristotle disputed Plato's theory of forms. There is no world of separate, abstract forms corresponding to the concrete things we perceive, he reasoned. Form cannot exist apart from particular objects, or as he put it, "No form without matter,

no matter without form." Accordingly, Aristotle rejected the notion that the Good exists independently of daily experience and human personality. In his view moral principles exist in the daily activities of human life and can be discovered by examining those activities. Happiness is to be attained by developing one's potential for a life of reason. The life of reason has two aims the pursuit of truth through reflection and understanding and the pursuit of virtue through intelligent conduct. Virtue, for Aristotle, represented a midpoint between extremes of excess and defect. (Some actions, however, like murder or theft, he saw as bad in themselves and therefore having no midpoint.)

Not all thinkers of the classical period shared the philosophical tradition of Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle. The Cyrenaics, for example, and later the Epicureans emphasized human feelings and desires and taught that the measure of an action is the amount of pleasure it brings. (This view is known as *hedonism*.) Epicurus, however, made a sharp distinction between "natural" pleasures, such as peace of mind and the absence of hunger, and "unnatural" pleasures, such as greed and lust, approving only the former. In contrast to the Cyrenaics and Epicureans were the Cynics and then the Stoics. These groups stressed overcoming feelings and desires and serving the demands of duty as revealed by reason.

As we shall see, many of the differences in viewpoint that existed during the classical period, such as the difference over pleasure and duty, have continued to divide thinkers through the centuries.

THE MEDIEVAL PERIOD

The second period in the history of ethics in the West is the medieval period, which extends from 500 to 1500. Its intellectual and social context was Christianity. As the belief system of Christianity (itself a product of Judaic thought) expanded across Europe, the idea of the citizen's relation to the state was replaced by the idea of the individual's obligation to God as set forth in the Bible and interpreted by the Church. Medieval ethics combined the classical emphasis on human reason with the idea of obedience to God's will.

Two great thinkers dominated medieval thought. The first was Saint Augustine (354-430). In his numerous works, notable among them *Confessions* and *The City of God*, Augustine made Plato's philosophy the basis of Christian ethics. Augustine's system was two-sided. On the one side, the life of reason leads to temporal well-being; on the other, faith leads to salvation and eternal happiness. (Since this life is only a preparation for the afterlife, Augustine taught, no real happiness is possible here.) The concept of Good for Augustine was similarly two-sided: the natural earthly side and the supernatural, other-worldly side, with the super-natural dominating. Augustine viewed man as having fallen from God's grace through original sin but retaining free will and responsibility for his actions. Virtue is possible, he taught, but to have real value it must be prompted by faith.

The Platonic system of Augustine was so emphasized in the early middle ages that Aristotle was all but forgotten until the time of the second great medieval thinker, Saint Thomas Aquinas (1225-1274). Aquinas rediscovered Aristotle, Christianized his philosophy, and made it the basis of the philosophical outlook of the later middle ages. Aquinas's greatest works were *Summa Theologica* and *Summa Contra Gentes*.

Aquinas aimed at demonstrating the harmony between Aristotle and Christianity. He taught that ethics has two dimensions—the natural and the theological. Natural

ethics, as detailed by Aristotle, consists of the development of reason and practice in living morally and leads to earthly happiness. Theological ethics consists of achieving the virtues of faith, hope, and charity through God's grace and leads to eternal life with God. Aquinas believed that the Natural Law -the divine law as written in the heart of man can be discovered by reason and cultivated by conscience. By allowing people to turn to secular knowledge without guilt, Aquinas prepared the way for the emergence of a more scientific view of humanity." and of ethics.

THE MODERN PERIOD

The third period in the history of ethics extends from 1500 to the present. The sixteenth and seventeenth centuries were times of intellectual upheaval. The Protestant Reformation challenged the supremacy of the "Roman Catholic church and introduced the idea of each person interpreting the Bible for himself or herself. The impact of this idea was increased with the invention of the printing press and the shift from Latin to the vernacular. Finally, and perhaps most importantly, the work of scientists like Copernicus, Galileo, and Harvey turned the attention of philosophers from theological to scientific explanations.

Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679) was the first thinker to systematically approach ethics from a scientific viewpoint. Hobbes, whose major philosophical work was *Leviathan*, argued that the notion of mechanistic materialism that was central to the physics of the time applied to ethics as well. He attempted to demonstrate that in humanity's natural (primitive) condition the rule of self-preservation produces a morality based on *self-interest*. In that condition, Hobbes reasoned, the concepts of right and wrong do not exist; they only begin to exist when civil society is formed. The only way civil society can control the pursuit of individuals' self-interest and the conflict that such pursuit inevitably generates is to have everyone give allegiance to the sovereign. Hobbes believed in the Golden Rule, but he also believed that people could not be trusted to practice it. With too much at stake for each person to follow his or her conscience, Hobbes argued, the sovereign power-whether "monarch or assembly"-must ensure "the safety of the people."

There was strong reaction against Hobbes' ethical perspective. In refutation of that perspective a number of ethicists argued that human beings are not at the mercy of their drive for self-preservation. They have a moral faculty, a specific intellectual guide that enables them to tell right from wrong. Several different ways of describing that moral faculty were advanced. **Some described it as intuition, others as a moral sense (a natural affection for virtue), and still others as conscience.**

In the early eighteenth-century David Hume (1711-1766) proposed an ethical theory that was in some ways reminiscent of John Locke's theory in the previous century. Locke (1632-1704) had argued that pleasure is the standard of moral judgment. Sensations of pleasure or pain he reasoned, lead us to reflect and form views of justice and goodness and thus develop a system of moral judgment. Hume believed that the standard of moral judgment is two-sided. One part of it is objective-the consequences of the action in question. The other part, the dominant part, in Hume's view, is subjective-a feeling of pleasure. (Like most hedonistic philosophers Hume did not approve of doing anything we wish. He believed that every human being possesses a tendency to be more pleased by benefiting others than by being selfish and self-indulgent.) In Hume's theory reason alone cannot answer moral questions. But a "moral sentiment" that chooses what is useful or pleasant can and does do so.